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A Quick Guide to SNAP Eligibility and Benefits

Most families and individuals who meet the program's income guidelines are eligible for the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP, formerly the Food Stamp Program). The size of a family's SNAP benefit is based on its income and certain expenses. This paper provides a short summary of SNAP eligibility and benefit calculation rules that are in effect for federal fiscal year 2026, which began in October 2025.

Impact of Shutdown and Recent Law Changes

Congress failed to enact an appropriation for fiscal year 2026 by October 1, resulting in many aspects of the federal government being temporarily shut down. The Department of Agriculture (USDA) has indicated that states should issue SNAP benefits for October 2025 as regularly scheduled. Individuals with questions about the status of SNAP during the shutdown should contact their state human services office. (See box, "How to Find Out If You Can Get Help From SNAP.")

Some SNAP households will lose SNAP eligibility or have their benefits cut starting in late 2025 or in 2026 as a result of the Republican megabill that President Trump signed into law on July 4, 2025. In particular, some people will be cut from SNAP due to the law's expansion of a rule limiting SNAP to three months in a three-year period for certain individuals who can't document that they are exempt (for example, because of a disability) or are working or participating in a qualifying activity for 20 hours a week or more. In addition, certain immigrants who are living lawfully in the United States and have been granted humanitarian protection by the federal government will be cut from SNAP, and benefits will be reduced for some households without an elderly or disabled member who can't provide documentation of their utility costs.

Many current participants will face these cuts when their SNAP eligibility is next recertified. States recertify eligibility for most SNAP households every six or 12 months. If a state takes action earlier than the next recertification, the household should receive a notice and an opportunity to provide additional information before their benefits are terminated or reduced.[1]

[1] Katie Bergh and Dottie Rosenbaum, "Many Low-Income People Will Soon Begin to Lose Food Assistance Under Republican Megabill," CBPP, September 10, 2025, https://www.cbpp.org/research/food-assistance/many-low-income-people-will-soon-begin-to-lose-food-assistance-under.

How to Find Out If You Can Get Help From SNAP

If you would like help from SNAP, contact your local human services office. The staff there will work with you to find out if you qualify.

You can also contact your state human services agency if you have questions about your benefit or to update your information if one of the following applies, as it may increase your benefit:

- If you recently lost income; or
- If you experienced a recent increase in certain expenses, or you think the state doesn't know about these expenses: housing or child care costs, child support payments, or if someone in your household who is aged 60 or older or has a disability has monthly medical expenses of $35 or more.

Find each state's website and telephone number

Find a local food bank for immediate food help

Notes: SNAP is often referred to by its former name, the Food Stamp Program; your state may use a different name. SNAP has special rules following natural disasters.

Determining Eligibility

Under federal rules, to be eligible for SNAP benefits a household's[2] income and resources must meet three tests, though income and asset limits are higher for households that are categorically eligible for SNAP, and most states have raised income and asset limits using "broad-based categorical eligibility."[3]

- **Gross monthly income** — that is, household income before any of the program's deductions are applied — generally must be at or below 130 percent of the poverty line. For a family of three, the poverty line used to calculate SNAP benefits in federal fiscal year 2026 is $2,221 a month. Thus, 130 percent of the poverty line for a three-person family is $2,888 a month, or about $34,656 a year. The poverty level is higher for bigger families and lower for smaller families.[4]
- **Net income,** or household income after deductions are applied, must be at or below the poverty line.

[2] A "household" for SNAP consists of individuals who live together in the same residence and who purchase and prepare food together.

[3] Broad-based categorical eligibility (BBCE) is a state policy option that most states have adopted to raise SNAP income limits somewhat so that low-income working families that have difficulty making ends meet, such as because they face costly housing or child care expenses, can receive help affording adequate food. The policy also lets states adopt less restrictive asset tests so that low-income households can have modest savings without losing SNAP. See USDA, "Broad-Based Categorical Eligibility (BBCE)," https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/broad-based-categorical-eligibility, for a list of states that have lifted the income and/or asset tests for most of the caseload by expanding categorical eligibility.

[4] Households with members who are older adults or have a disability are not subject to the gross income test.

- **Assets** must fall below certain limits: households without a member who is aged 60 or older or has a disability must have assets of $3,000 or less; households *with* such a member must have assets of $4,500 or less.

What counts as income? SNAP counts cash income from all sources, including earned income (before payroll taxes are deducted) and unearned income such as cash assistance, Social Security, unemployment insurance, and child support.

What counts as an asset? Generally, resources that could be available to the household to purchase food, such as amounts in bank accounts, count as assets. Items that are not accessible, such as the household's home, personal property, and retirement savings, do not count. Most automobiles do not count.[5]

Who is <u>not</u> eligible? Some categories of people are not eligible for SNAP regardless of their income or assets, such as individuals who are on strike, all people without a documented immigration status, many immigrants with lawful immigration statuses,[6] some students attending college more than half time,[7] and certain people with drug-related felony convictions in some states.

Who faces a time limit on receiving SNAP unless they meet additional requirements? Many adults aged 18 through 64 who do not have children under age 14 in the home and do not have disabilities are limited to three months of SNAP benefits every three years if they are not working or in a work or training program at least 20 hours a week. States have broad authority to extend work requirements to many other SNAP households. (See box, "SNAP's Three-Month Time Limit.")

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[5] Federal SNAP rules count the market value of most vehicles above a dollar threshold ($4,650) toward the asset limit, but states have significant flexibility to apply less restrictive vehicle asset rules, and every state has adopted this flexibility.

[6] Under the Republican megabill enacted in July 2025, only U.S. citizens, lawful permanent residents (after a five-year waiting period, if applicable), people granted Cuban or Haitian entrant status, and people who live in the United States under a Compact of Free Association (COFA) can qualify for SNAP. In some cases, the income and resources of the immigrant's sponsor count toward the immigrant's eligibility. For detailed information on non-citizens' eligibility for SNAP, see https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/recipient/eligibility/non-citizen.

[7] For more information on college student eligibility, see https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/students.

SNAP's Three-Month Time Limit

Many non-disabled adults aged 18 through 64 without children under age 14 need to meet additional requirements to remain eligible for SNAP.

Individuals aged 18 through 64 are limited to three months of SNAP benefits every three years unless they are working, volunteering, or in a work or training program at least 20 hours a week. Some individuals are exempt from this work-reporting requirement (also referred to as a time limit). They include people who are determined to be physically or mentally unfit for work, are pregnant, live with children under age 14 in the household, or are American Indian or Alaska Native, among others. (Prior to the Republican megabill enacted in July 2025, only individuals aged 18 to 54 without children in the household were subject to the time limit, and veterans, former foster youth, people experiencing homelessness, and people living with someone under age 18 were exempt.)

States can request temporary waivers of the work-reporting requirement in areas with high unemployment. Individuals subject to the time limit can continue to receive SNAP benefits if they live in a state that has waived it in the area in which they reside. However, the Republican megabill restricted waivers to areas where unemployment rates exceed 10 percent, so that only a small number of areas continue to qualify for a waiver. Areas in Alaska and Hawai'i where the unemployment rate is at or above 150 percent of the national unemployment rate also qualify for waivers.

More general information on the work-reporting requirement is available at https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/work-requirements. For detailed eligibility requirements in a given state, consult the state SNAP agency.

Calculating Benefit Amounts

SNAP expects families receiving benefits to spend 30 percent of their net income on food. Families with no net income receive the maximum benefit, which is tied to the cost of USDA's Thrifty Food Plan (TFP). The TFP represents the cost of purchasing and preparing a nutritionally adequate diet, consistent with the Dietary Guidelines for Americans, for people in low-income households, assuming they take significant steps to stretch their food budget.

For households with net income, the monthly SNAP benefit equals the maximum benefit for that household size minus the household's expected contribution of 30 percent of its net income.[8]

TABLE 1

SNAP Benefits by Household Size, Fiscal Year 2026

Household Size	Maximum Monthly Benefit	Estimated Average Monthly Benefit
1	$298	$204
2	$546	$370
3	$785	$588
4	$994	$715
5	$1,183	$839
6	$1,421	$954

[8] Eligible households with one or two members qualify for at least a "minimum benefit," which is $24 in fiscal year 2026 for 48 states and the District of Columbia (with higher amounts for Alaska, Hawai'i, Guam, and the Virgin Islands).

7	$1,571	$996
8	$1,789	$1,246
Each additional person	$218	

Note: Estimated average benefits are based on fiscal year 2023 SNAP Quality Control Household Characteristics data, the most recent data with this information, adjusted to incorporate the updated SNAP parameters for fiscal year 2026 and inflated to incorporate increases in income and expenses. Programmatic changes to SNAP due to the Republican megabill enacted in July 2025, such as the expansion of the three-month time limit and reduction of the standard utility allowance, will cause a shift in caseloads and benefits that may result in different average monthly benefits than presented here.

Source: USDA, "SNAP FY 2026 Cost-of-Living Adjustments," August 13, 2025, https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/allotment/cola/fy26. SNAP benefits in Alaska, Hawai'i, Guam, and the Virgin Islands are higher than in the other 48 states and Washington, D.C. because income eligibility standards, maximum benefits, and deduction amounts are different in those states and territories.

Table 1 shows the maximum SNAP benefit levels and estimated average benefits in fiscal year 2026 for households of different sizes. For example, consider a family of three: if that family had no income, it would receive the maximum benefit of $785 per month; if it had $600 in net monthly income, it would receive the maximum benefit ($785) minus 30 percent of its net income (30 percent of $600 is $180), or $605. We estimate the average benefit per person in fiscal year 2026 will be $188 per month or $6.17 per day.

Deductions play an important role in determining SNAP benefits. They reflect the fact that not all of a household's income is available for purchasing food; some must be used to meet other needs. In determining available (or net) income, the program allows the following deductions from a household's gross monthly income:

- **standard deduction** to account for basic unavoidable costs;[9]
- **earnings deduction** equal to 20 percent of earnings (this accounts for work-related expenses and payroll taxes while also acting as a work incentive);
- **dependent care deduction** for the out-of-pocket child care or other dependent care expenses that are necessary for a household member to work or participate in education or training;
- **child support deduction** for any legally obligated child support that a household member pays;[10]
- **medical expense deduction** for out-of-pocket medical expenses greater than $35 a month that a household member who is an older adult or has a disability incurs;[11] and

[9] The standard deduction varies by household size. For example, in 48 states and D.C., it is $209 for households of one to three members and $223, $261, and $299 for households with four, five, and six or more members, respectively (fiscal year 2026).

[10] Some states have replaced the deduction for child support payments with an income exclusion in the same amount under a state option from the 2002 farm bill.

[11] To simplify processes for both households and states, about half of states have set a standard monthly medical expense deduction that households can claim if their monthly medical expenses exceed $35. There is evidence that suggests this deduction is underutilized. See Ty Jones, "SNAP's Excess Medical Expense Deduction: Targeting Food Assistance to Low-Income Seniors and Individuals With Disabilities," CBPP, August 20, 2014, http://www.cbpp.org/research/snaps-excess-medical-expense-deduction.

- **excess shelter deduction**, set at the amount by which the household's housing costs (including utilities[12]) exceed half of its net income after all other deductions. For example, the excess shelter deduction in 48 states and D.C. is limited to $744 in 2026 unless at least one household member is an older adult or has a disability.[13]

All SNAP households can receive the standard deduction. Over two-thirds (68 percent) of SNAP households claim the shelter deduction, while 28 percent of households (and over half of households with children) claim the earnings deduction. By contrast, the medical, dependent care, and child support deductions are claimed by small shares of SNAP households: 5 percent, 2 percent, and 1 percent, respectively.[14] (For an example of how deductions affect benefit levels, see box, "Example: Calculating a Household's Monthly SNAP Benefits.")

[12] To simplify SNAP benefit calculations, states are permitted to add a "standard utility allowance" (SUA) to a household's other housing costs and use the resulting sum when determining the family's shelter deduction, rather than requiring verification of actual utility expenses. Under prior law, households receiving more than $20 in annual benefits under the Low-Income Home Energy Assistance Act of 1981 or other similar energy assistance programs automatically qualified for the heating and cooling SUA (HCSUA). But under the Republican megabill enacted in July 2025, such households automatically qualify only if they have an elderly or disabled member; other households will have to provide documentation of their heating and cooling expenses.

[13] For a detailed analysis of the shelter deduction, see Dorothy Rosenbaum, Daniel Tenny, and Sam Elkin, "The Food Stamp Shelter Deduction: Helping Households with High Housing Burdens Meet Their Food Needs," CBPP, June 2002, http://www.cbpp.org/7-1-02fs.pdf.

[14] See Table A.9 in Mia Monkovic and Ben Ward, "Characteristics of SNAP Households: Fiscal Year 2023," USDA, April 2025, https://www.fns.usda.gov/research/snap/characteristics-fy23.

Example: Calculating a Household's Monthly SNAP Benefits

Consider a family of three with one full-time worker, two children, dependent care costs of $56 a month, and shelter costs of $1,198 per month.[a]

- **Step 1 — Gross Income:** Full-time work for this worker yields monthly earnings of $1,672.[b]
- **Step 2 — Net Income for Shelter Deduction:** Begin with the gross monthly earnings of $1,672. Subtract the standard deduction for a three-person household ($209), the earnings deduction (20 percent times $1,672 or about $334), and the child care deduction ($56). The result is roughly $1,073 (Countable Income A).
- **Step 3 — Shelter Deduction:** Begin with the shelter costs of $1,198. Subtract half of Countable Income A (half of $1,073 is $537) for a result of $661. This is below the shelter deduction cap of $744, so the shelter deduction for this household is $661.
- **Step 4 — Net Income:** Subtract the shelter deduction ($661) from Countable Income A ($1,073) for a result of $412.
- **Step 5 — Family's Expected Contribution Toward Food:** 30 percent of the household's net income ($412) is about $124.
- **Step 6 — SNAP Benefit:** The maximum benefit in 2026 for a family of three is $785. The maximum benefit minus the household contribution ($785 minus $124) equals $661. The family's monthly SNAP benefit is $661.[c]

[a] The $56 monthly dependent care costs in this example represent the average co-payment that states required in their child care assistance programs in 2024 for a family of three at the poverty line with one child in child care, according to the National Women's Law Center report, "Decision Point: State Child Care Assistance Policies 2024," May 20, 2025, https://nwlc.org/resource/decision-point-state-child-care-assistance-policies-2024/. The assumption of $1,198 for shelter costs represents median shelter expenses in 2023 for working families earning at least $500 per month with three members, including two children, based on a CBPP analysis of 2023 SNAP Quality Control data, inflated to fiscal year 2026 dollars.

[b] The assumption of $1,672 for monthly earnings represents average earned income for SNAP households with earned income, based on 2023 SNAP Quality Control data, inflated to fiscal year 2026 dollars.

[c] Calculations are rounded.